

WOMEN IN DEBATE: FROM VIRTUAL TO MATERIAL

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Normally I would be less than pleased if another debater poked me, but in this instance, I was flattered. I logged onto Facebook and saw that a friend and fellow debater had virtually “poked” me (the “real life” equivalent to a flirty or friendly smile). I poked her back and attached a cute note. Then we chatted, shared pictures and stories from the past weekend, and promised to “talk” again soon. I am but one of the millions who perform at least part of their interpersonal maintenance in cyberspace that night.

Virtual spaces like Facebook (www.facebook.com) and Myspace (www.myspace.com) offer today’s generation of online users a discursive space to experience “communal affiliation around shared experiences” (Mitra, 1997, p. 176). Like many groups, debaters¹ take to cyber-communities as a means to overcome geographical distance. The ability to transcend space and time (there is always *someone* online) is one of the greatest benefits to virtual communication. These virtual spaces are one of the many ways debaters have integrated technology into their activity. As evidenced by this forum, the community use technologies, to both improve (gathering information faster, making tournament entrees more efficient, etc.) and expand (debating globally via the internet, real time web casts of debate rounds, etc.) almost every facet of the activity. While emerging technologies might bring logistical efficiency, some fear their emotional cost. Critics of technology fear that the loss of interpersonal communication will strain the already tenuous connections in the community. Yet I argue that amidst the limitations of technology lays its possibilities.

Like so many other high school and college activities, policy debate lacks gender, racial, and ethnic diversity (Bartenan, 1995, 1998; Bile, 1999; Bruschke & Johnson, 1994; Crenshaw, 1993a, 1993b; Hunt & Simerly, 1999; Frank, 1997; Friedley & Manchester, 1985; Loge, 1991; Louge, 1986, 1987, 1993; McRee & Cote, 2002; Rowland, 1993; Sowards, 1999a, 1999b; Stepp, 1997a, 1997b; Stepp & Gardner, 2001a, 2001b; Tuman, 1993; Wilkins & Hobbs, 1997; Williams, McGee & McGee, 1999; Zompetti, 1999, 2004). Sadly, policy debate is plagued with hierarchies that often disproportionately privilege white, economically advantaged men (Warner, 2003). The explanations and excuses for these significant inequities are endless and solutions often lacking. Notable community members invest considerable time and effort developing new pedagogy, league structure, and specialized debate camps, in an effort to breakdown privilege, yet many debate participants continue with business as usual. While the fears of emerging technology's use in debate may be well founded, technology, I argue, is for some already providing solutions.

In the remainder of this essay I consider how underrepresented groups of debaters turn to virtual communities as a means to overcome the oppressive invisibility they encounter in the "real public sphere" of debate² (Mitra, 2004, p. 492). Through a critical reading of women-in-debate and their virtual communities, I advance the argument that new digital technologies are capable of producing discursive spaces where those lacking public agency in debate can find a new found sense of can-do-ness. In what follows, I make three distinct, yet related moves.

First, I detail some of the unique obstacles women in the debate community face. I intend neither to elevate, nor bifurcate, the subject position of women as distinct from other privileged or disadvantaged socially constructed categories. Instead, I recognize my own experience as a white woman in debate as a subjective lens through which my scholarship is distinctively and inevitably informed. Further, my commitment to increasing the involvement and retention of women in debate has granted me unique access to virtual communities where self-identified female debaters reside.

Second, I consider the distinctive elements of social networking sites as exemplars of the virtual spaces where women debaters seek community. Drawing upon some of the rich communication scholarship on virtual communities, I explain some of the many ways in which these spaces offer a means of virtual visibility to young women in debate. I conclude by suggesting that virtual spaces are one practical means by which underrepresented groups can cultivate a sense of agency and community in what is, for better or worse, a traditionally adversarial debate environment.

About Women in Debate

When outsiders ask about debate I often compare the competition to a tennis match. The squad travels long distances to a tournament, arrives with various teams of two, and gives it their all before elimination. Yet the game simulation paradigm of debate, as Alfred Snider puts it, claims no outright distinction between men and women (1987, 2003). Teams are both coed and single-sexed. Even so, women are documented as having less overall competitive success, judge fewer elimination rounds, and have a higher drop out rate (Bile, 1999; Bruschke & Johnson, 1994; Friedley & Manchester, 1985; Hunt & Simerly, 1999; Logue, 1986; Medcalf, 1984; Rowland, 1993; Stepp & Gardner, 2001a, 2001b; Stepp, Simerly, & Logue, 1997; Szwapa, 1994; Warner, 2003; Zompetti, 1999, 2004). Evidence suggests that high school women take great interest in debate (McRee & Cote, 2002), but rarely do they stay committed through college. Stepp, Simerly, and Logue (1994) lay blame on sexual harassers, while critic Ede Warner Jr. (2003) charges the stylistic preferences of the game. Their arguments are not mutually exclusive.

As a white woman debater, my experience (leave it to the female author to introduce both *pathos* and experience) enables me to understand that the policy debate community's exclusion is often not intentional or conscious. Never-the-less the burden of often being the only women—in a debate round, on the bus, in the hotel room, and/or at the coaches' meeting—is taxing. Even the most competitively successful women are habitually expected to yield, pursue, and embody, essentialist features.

As debaters, women are often projected to be the most physically attractive, organized, caring, and likely to cry when things do not go their way. Further, women debaters are rewarded competitively for communicating like men, yet punished socially for the same. While I do not believe women and men have biological or innate communication styles, women and men are socialized towards different types of speech. Male patterns of speech (aggressive, assertive, and rational) are privileged in debate. Thus, female debaters must work doubly hard to uphold their outside-debate social speech style (for fear of being labeled a bitch) while also mastering the masculine privileged communication style of debate. Women coaches are especially affected by these essentialist presumptions. The general expectation is that female coaches will organize travel, nurture the sad and frustrated, feed the hungry, look great in the picture, all while placing the same high level of commitment their male peers do into argument construction and coaching.

I am in no way suggesting that all women possess these skills, nor do I think they lack the agency to dismiss the misgivings of their peers. Further, my articulation of sexism in debate should not be read to imply that the activity lacks organized, nurturing, intelligent, feminist, male role models, for it most certainly does. My point is that punishing overt sexual harassment or removing stylistic barriers to competitive success will not eliminate the more ingrained barriers to women's inclusion in intercollegiate debate. Simply, no woman should have to choose between sleeping in a hotel room with men and being alone. The cycle is challenging; the fewer women that make the transition (high school to college, debater to coach, graduate student to director, etc.) the fewer role models there are.

Sexism, like many other forms of oppression does not parade itself through the halls with a banner naming its masters and slaves. Instead, and even among those with the best of intentions, sexism is infested into the logics that constitute our everyday understandings of normality and even success. As Warner eloquently states, privilege creeps into most subtle, and covert of spaces (2003, p.4). Yet, if the rewards of debate are to be extended

to all students, the recognition of engrained subjugation must be a call—not an obstacle, nor an excuse—for its removal.

Sisterhood is Virtually Vocal

A few members of the debate community fight oppression in various ways. Some gestures are simple and others grander in scope.³ One such example is the emergence of the *Women's Debate Institute*. This not-for-profit organization holds an annual four day retreat in Port Townsend, Washington each summer with the goal of building a “supportive community” and “a debate environment that’s welcoming to women” (Women's Debate Institute, para.3). Former debaters Jeff Shaw and Kari Thorene Shaw started this exclusive institute in 2001 to encourage high school women and provide a social network of women debaters, coaches, directors, and mentors (Bednarz, 2004). While the event is empowering, it is what the debaters did with it upon returning home, that is most impressive.

Upon leaving camp this past summer debaters took it upon themselves to extend the community and network initiated at the institute into the virtual spaces of internet. Within days of arriving home I was inundated with email invitations to join both Myspace and Facebook⁴ groups. A bit apprehensive, I joined. What I found was a virtual community of women debaters—many of whom did not even attend the camp.

Both Myspace and Facebook can be considered social networking sites. Information scholar danah boyd (2006a) explains social networking sites as “a category of websites with profiles, semi-persistent public commentary on the profile, and a traversable publicly articulated social network displayed in relation to the profile.” Like other social networking sites, entrance to Myspace and Facebook requires the construction of a personal profile (Adamic, Buyukkokten, and Adar, 2003). Profiles range in detail and but often include, name, contact information, birthday, school, interests, photographs, favorite quotes, and music. Having a profile entitles users to send public or private emails, join clubs or groups, display photographs or art, post events, and search for people by location or interest. If a user identifies people they know, or desire

to know, they can request to befriend them. If they agree, their friendship is traversable, a publicly articulated social network (boyd, 2006a). boyd explains,

Participants have the ability to list other profiles as "friends" or "contacts" or some equivalent. This generates a social network graph which may be directed ("attention network" type of social network where friendship does not have to be confirmed) or undirected (where the other person must accept friendship). This articulated social network is displayed on an individual's profile for all other users to view. Each node contains a link to the profile of the other person so that individuals can traverse the network through friends of friends of friends....

These friendships are the "backbone of networked participation" (boyd, 2006b). While these friendships may have grown out of preexisting social formations, (i.e. women who met at camp) the virtual community can (and in this case does) extend itself to women with similar interests (Matei, 2005, p.346).

Myspace or Facebook friends are both similar and dislike "real" friendships. Like non-virtual or "real" friendship, online relationships take on a variety of forms. You can limit a friend's access to your personal information, just as you would in real life, or open up your profile like a book and let them read it all (this is an important feature I will attend to shortly).

One significant difference is the way in which users go about making friends. Because friends can be sought out through common interest and group affiliation, it may be easier to ask someone to be your virtual friend than it may be to approach them in person. The initiation of friendship is especially important for individuals lacking community. In the case of the women in debate this means that all kinds of females interested in debate often befriend one another. The barriers of age, skill, location, style of debate, economics, among other constructions, are removed. For example, the 49 women registered on the women in debate Facebook site include women of all skill levels from novice high school debaters to National Debate Tournament competitors. High school coaches, college professors, debaters of all ages, and alumni

unite on the site. In this space the community of women in debate is formed. Online, women post pictures of their experiences and voice their stories, beliefs, concerns and desires. The expansion of virtual communities like these, provide the possibility for a liberating, safe, and empowering space (Mitra & Watts, 2002) where the women of debate could (and still do) share common voices and agency.

Recently there has been an explosion of research detailing how, and in what ways, the internet provides cathartic experiences for marginalized communities (e.g., Dietrich, 1997; Palczewski, 2001; Mitra, 1997a, 1997b, 2001, 2004, 2006; Mitra & Watts, 2002; Rheingold, 1993; Shaw, 1997; Wellman, 2001; Wenjing, 2005). While these virtual communities are relatively new, the desire for social networks between individuals that share interests is not. The history of women's consciousness-raising groups provides one such example of ways in which individuals with common interests and situations seek out community. When defining cyber-communities Feenberg & Bakardjieva (2004) have, rightly in my view, turned to Benedict Anderson's (1983) notion of imagined communities. "All communities larger than primordial villages of face-to-face contact (and perhaps even these) are imagined," Anderson argues. "Communities are to be distinguished, not by their falsity/genuineness, but by the style in which they are imagined" (Anderson, 1983, p.6). While virtual communities may be imagined, their effect is material. For women debaters on Facebook and Myspace, their discursive environments are safe and sacred spaces where they can make and meet friends, cultivate community, and overcome senses of isolation and alienation (Mitra, 1997a).

This should not be read to suggest that women debaters are homogenous or always agree with their virtual peers, rather that the traditional balance of power between the center and margin is transcended by the technology itself. Ananda Mitra and Eric Watts (2002) explain:

In the traditional organization of cultural production, it is relatively simple to identify the central voice, and thereafter the peripheral and marginal Other. For

example, in traditional media, the marginal has to constantly struggle to be heard whereas the power of the central either drowns out the call of the marginal or co-opts the marginal voice and 'claws back' the marginalized into the mainstream..In other words, a fundamental shift is occurring with respect to distribution of power between the center and the margin. The center, which has traditionally been defined by the strength of its technology and capital, is challenged precisely because of the way in which the texts on the web are organized and interconnected. These shifts are related to the way in which individuals and institutions are choosing to voice themselves, as well as the way in which the dialogic potential of the discourse of individual agents/speaker is being exercised. (pp. 487-488)

In virtual communities women debaters do not have to jockey for speech time. The traditional notions of feminist consciousness-raising produce a sense of community by affirming that women's experiences are not isolated or unique. Through the exchange of narratives, women learn that their experiences as debaters, be them celebratory or oppressive, are not individual events but rather experiences had by many. The lack of centralized power is due in part to shared participant *purpose*, the lack of centralized power, and the inclusion of multiple speech patterns. Simply, the masculine political culture that defines/permeates the "real" debate sphere is absent. Further, rarely if ever, have I witnessed individual experiences mocked or attacked the way they have been on mainstream listserves like edebate (www.ndtceda.com).

Edebate illustrates that social networking benefits are not innate to all internet technologies. Edebate, for all intensive purposes, is a mainstream listserve that provides its thousands of users a space to exchange information. Yet anyone who has witnessed the virtual violence women, who have attempted to combat sexism through edebate, have faced, knows can be anything but a safe space. Kristina Shriver and Serena Turley (2003) publicly detailed the apprehension and fear many female debaters have towards edebate. Witnessing the community attack a

women's post provides more than enough deterrent to other women that might have ever considered posting. Media scholar Danielle Weise (2005) likens this type of listserve to a bulletin board of the internet (358). The limitation of listserves such as edebate, Weise argues, is their varying levels of openness. Unlike the user-controlled Myspace or Facebook (where the profiler has to accept you as a friend before you can see their face, so to speak) listserves enable anyone to contact you with any type of content (2005, 2004). You can not remove their post from your wall, you can not elect to unfriend them or leave that group, your exchange is public and so is the response. Thus, the protected space of the social networking groups is an essential function for already marginalized communities.

The technology enables group administrators to invite and block participation on these sites. While this type of exclusion may be perceived as elitist, history supports the claim that traditionally marginalized groups strive in safe counter publics not penetrated by members of the dominant culture (in this case the larger debate community). The strength of virtual communities, Mitra argues, is the technological "peculiarities that can be mobilized to produce a sense of safety for displaced people. Yet where my argument extends beyond Mitra's is my belief that the community that produces agency through cultivating common history and experience has the ability to move outside of the virtual and into "real" physical spaces. Simply, those that may have been only virtually connected can interact in real space of the tournament.

From Virtual to Material Inclusively

The more people I met in the activity the more enjoyable debate became. At the beginning of my college career (I did not debate in high school), the only women I knew were the ones on my squad, and there were many. I learned quickly, however, that my team was an exception to the norm. For so many women in debate they are one of the only, if not *the only*, female on the team. When the opportunity to meet other women arrives, they are interpolated as either opponents or judges—both positions that pit women against one another often resulting in defensive and

hierarchical, rather than open and honest, communication. Tournaments are action-packed weekends with little, if any, social time to nurture an opponent into a friend. Yet evidence and experience suggests that if people are friends (regardless of how they met) prior to their introduction in an adversarial environment, their friendship extends beyond their relationship as opponents.

There is little doubt that virtual communities like Facebook and Myspace are powerful dwelling spaces in which women debaters find community. Social networking, as boyd has suggested and women and debate have come to learn, is “deeply connected to participant’s offline social life . . . social networks are not digital spaces disconnected from other social venues” (16). Cyber-communities have the potential to extend beyond the virtual and produce a community of women in debate where there had once been disconnected individuals. Cyberspace offers impressive opportunities to transform traditionally invisible and silenced groups into vocal agency-laden communities where strength is cultivated through shared experiences and commitment to an activity, like intercollegiate debate. If the support women gain from virtual communities can improve even a few women’s experiences in the material practice of debate, and I have to believe it can, then we as supporters of debate, mentors of our students, and believers in diversity, must foster access to this technology. The existence of online community authorizes the offline community—cyberspace has cultural capital. Imagine how different women’s experiences in debate could be if they felt overall that it was safe and inclusive space.

One of the greatest challenges of our generation is to make sense of the discourses circulating within and about technology. We write out and practice the ethics of the apparatus in the very same moment as its emergence. Economic access to technology is a barrier that must be overcome, and the facets of both its potential and limitations must continue to be explored. At the same time, debate as an activity must be willing to change. The homogenous and often exclusionary tactics of debaters and coaches must give way to new spaces for communities that foster

affirmation of ideas and experience. Virtual community building is one of the many ways in which this can happen.

What amazes me most about today's virtual communities is that they are so often organized and facilitated by those who need them. While coaches and administrators spend time and money trying to research the diversity question, our students are seeking out their own solutions. Few who have witnessed the power of debate can deny its ability to transform listeners into critical thinkers; this is an experience that can not be protected for the already privileged. As invocators in the classroom most of us already know that the teacher-to-student pedagogical model no longer suffices. As technology and debate changes, I suggest we take cues from our students. We can learn from them by following them into *their* empowering spaces, be they virtual or material.

NOTES

¹ "Debaters" and "debate community" for the purposes of this essay refer specifically to the policy debate in the United States. While I have little doubt policy debate has much to learn from the parliamentary and forensic community both in the United States and abroad, both my research and experience limits both the scope and findings of this essay to U.S. policy debate.

² In suggesting that face-to-face debate is a "public sphere" I am not suggesting that there is a monolithic public sphere, but rather that the policy debate community makes up a public within which other publics, and counter-publics emerge. For more on the relationship between debate and publics see Mitchell, 1998.

³ Some of the specific efforts to celebrate women in debate include, but are not limited to, CEDA's Women's Wall, the Becky Galantine Award, the Seeking Transformative Against Nondiscrimination in Debate organization, Gorilla Girls Activism, mentoring programs, and Wake Forest's Women in Debate web site (<http://groups.wfu.edu/debate/HistoryPages/WomeninWaleDebate.htm>)

⁴ Facebook is one of the fastest growing online social networking groups. Acquisti and Gross's (2006) recent study offers in-depth demographic information about the site and its 9million users.

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